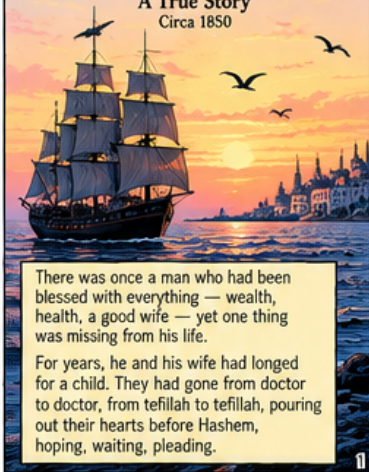


Ne'ilah The Last Knock

A Father's Journey
A True Story
Circa 1850



There was once a man who had been blessed with everything — wealth, health, a good wife — yet one thing was missing from his life.

For years, he and his wife had longed for a child. They had gone from doctor to doctor, from tefillah to tefillah, pouring out their hearts before Hashem, hoping, waiting, pleading.

And then, after many years, their prayers were answered. A son was born.



From that moment, the father's entire life revolved around the child. He cherished him as his most precious treasure.



He spared him nothing. The boy had the finest rebbeim, the best tutors, the warmest clothing, the healthiest food — whatever he needed, his father provided. But more than anything else, he gave him time, attention, and love. He lived for that boy.

Years passed, the child grew up, strong and capable, his father's pride and hope. Until one day, he came home with news that pained his father's heart.



It's what's best for me, Abba. It's time I make my own way.

The father said nothing more. What could he say? He had raised his son to be independent, to chase success — and now that moment had come. He would not stand in his way.

So, with love in his heart and his hands trembling, he helped his son pack his suitcase. He prepared the food for the journey, tucked a note into his bag, and walked him to the port.



Go with hatzlachah and follow Hashem and His Torah. And remember where home is.

The son embraced his father and boarded the ship. Slowly, the vessel began to move. The father raised his hand, watching until the figure of his son grew smaller and smaller, until it finally disappeared from sight.



He didn't move. He stood there, long after everyone else had gone, his coat tugging at his coat, the waves washing quietly against the dock. And as he gazed at the tefillah, chatzot, leilcha, the emcitis — It was as though a piece of his own soul had sailed away with that ship.

Years passed. The son built a new life abroad. He married, was blessed with children, and was successful in his work, his community, his growing responsibilities.



From time to time, he wrote letters home. They were brief but sincere, filled with updates — a new house, a business venture, the children's birthdays. The father cherished every letter, unfolding each one with trembling hands, reading and rereading each word, again and again.

But as the years went on, the letters grew fewer. The house grew quieter. The father would sit for long hours, holding each letter, always ending the same way:



My dear father,
It's not a good time.
The children are in school.
Perhaps next year.
With respect and love.

And each time, the reply would come — polite, apologetic, yet distant.

The father accepted each excuse with understanding. He knew his son meant well. But as the years went by, the letters stacked neatly on his desk — dozens of them — and he felt the weight of every missed Shabbos, every embrace that never happened.



Still, his love never faded. One day, he decided to go to him.

He prepared once again, packed his bag, and set out on the long journey.



I will see him!
I will hold my son
and his children.
It will be like
a new beginning.

The voyage was long and difficult. The sea breeze tugged at his coat, the waves washing quietly against the ship. He gazed at the horizon, his heart filled with hope.



Soon...
I will see him. He will
be so happy to see me.

At last, the ship drew into port. The father hired a carriage and went straight to his son's house. As the horses clattered through the streets, he whispered to himself, "Soon... soon I'll see him."



Just a little further.
He will be so happy
to see me.

He knocked softly at first — no answer. He knocked again — still silence. A third time, louder now.



At last, the door opened. His son came out, now a grown man, dressed in his house clothes. His wife and children were behind him.



I'm too tired.
Stay in the hotel
across the street.

The father stood there for a long moment, his heart breaking. He had dreamed of this moment for so many years.



He has no time
for me...

He turned away, walked back to the station, and boarded the ship. He didn't look back.



But in the morning, the son woke to the sound of birds and sunlight streaming through the shutters. He remembered.



My father!
I must go to the hotel
and bring him home now!

He hurried to the port, scanning the crowd. He looked around — left, right — again. But there was no one.

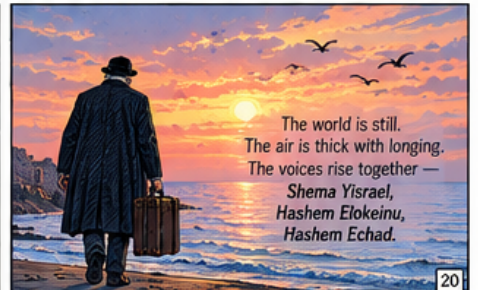


The ship had already sailed.



And that son who was too busy, too tired, who meant well but kept delaying — that son is us.

Kol Dodi Dofek
"My beloved child, I'm here.
Open for Me."
All year long. Hashem waits.



The world is still.
The air is thick with longing.
The voices rise together —
Shema Yisrael,
Hashem Elokeinu,
Hashem Echad.